

WEBRUM-02: SPA Instrumentation

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Overview

Single-Page Applications (SPAs) present unique challenges for Real User Monitoring. Unlike traditional multi-page apps where each navigation triggers a full page load, SPAs dynamically update content via JavaScript — meaning route changes, data fetches, and user interactions happen without the browser firing standard navigation events. Dynatrace addresses this with automatic SPA detection, XHR/fetch monitoring, route change tracking, and custom action naming.

Table of Contents

1. [SPA Monitoring Challenges](#)
 2. [RUM Injection Methods](#)
 3. [Route Change Detection](#)
 4. [Framework-Specific Instrumentation](#)
 5. [Custom Action Naming](#)
 6. [XHR and Fetch Monitoring](#)
 7. [Validating SPA Instrumentation](#)
 8. [Hybrid Apps: Mobile WebView + Desktop](#)
 9. [Summary and Next Steps](#)
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Prerequisites

Requirement	Details
Dynatrace Environment	SaaS with Grail enabled
RUM Enabled	At least one SPA with RUM injection active
Permissions	<code>storage:events:read</code> , <code>storage:entities:read</code>
Knowledge	Familiarity with SPA frameworks (Angular, React, or Vue.js)
Previous Notebook	WEBRUM-01: RUM Fundamentals

1. SPA Monitoring Challenges

Traditional RUM relies on browser navigation events (`load` , `DOMContentLoaded`) to detect page loads. SPAs break this model:

Challenge	Traditional App	SPA
Page load detection	Browser <code>load</code> event fires on every page	Only fires once on initial load
Route changes	Full HTTP request per page	JavaScript updates the URL and DOM
Data fetching	Server renders HTML with data	Client fetches data via XHR/fetch after load
User interactions	Links trigger navigation	Clicks trigger state changes without navigation
Timing measurement	Navigation Timing API covers full load	Custom timing needed for virtual route changes

Dynatrace handles these by:

- Monitoring `history.pushState` and `hashchange` events for route detection
- Tracking XHR/fetch calls triggered by user interactions
- Grouping related XHR calls into a single user action
- Detecting framework-specific lifecycle events for Angular, React, and Vue.js

Important: SPA monitoring requires the **Async Web Requests** and **SPA route changes** capture settings to be enabled in your web application configuration.

2. RUM Injection Methods

For SPAs, choose the injection method that matches your deployment architecture:

Automatic Injection (Recommended)

If your SPA is served by a web server with OneAgent installed, injection happens automatically. OneAgent modifies the HTML response to include the RUM JavaScript snippet in the `<head>` section.

```
<!-- Automatically injected by OneAgent -->
<script type="text/javascript" src="/ruxitagentjs_..." data-
dtconfig="..."></script>
```

Manual Injection

For SPAs served from CDNs or static hosting (S3, Netlify, Vercel) where no server-side OneAgent exists:

```
<!-- Add to <head> before other scripts -->
<script type="text/javascript" src="https://your-
activegate/jstag/managed/.../ruxitagentjs_..."
data-dtconfig="..."></script>
```

Agentless RUM (JavaScript Tag)

For environments where you cannot install OneAgent at all:

1. Navigate to **Digital Experience > Web Applications > Your App > Setup**
2. Select **Agentless monitoring**
3. Copy the generated `<script>` tag
4. Paste into your application's `index.html`

Tip: For SPAs built with modern bundlers (Webpack, Vite), you can inject the RUM tag via an HTML plugin to keep it out of source code.

3. Route Change Detection

Dynatrace detects SPA route changes by monitoring:

- `history.pushState()` / `history.replaceState()` — Used by most modern SPAs
- `hashchange` events — Used by hash-based routing (e.g., `/#/page`)
- **Framework-specific routing** — Angular Router, React Router, Vue Router

Each detected route change generates a **Route change** user action in Dynatrace, capturing:

Field	Description
<code>action.name</code>	The route change action name (e.g., "Route change to /dashboard")
<code>action.type</code>	RouteChange
<code>duration</code>	Time from route trigger to visual completeness
<code>xhr.count</code>	Number of XHR/fetch calls during the route change

Let's query route change actions to validate detection:

```
// Route change actions in the last hour – verify SPA detection is working
fetch user.events, from:-1h
| filter action.type == "RouteChange"
| summarize route_count = count(), avg_duration = avg(duration), by:
{action.name, app.name}
| sort route_count desc
| limit 20
```

4. Framework-Specific Instrumentation

Angular

Angular applications use the Angular Router with `history.pushState`. Dynatrace automatically detects:

- Route changes via `NavigationEnd` events
- Zone.js async tracking for XHR/fetch calls
- Component lifecycle events

Configuration tips:

- Enable **Async Web Requests** capture for Zone.js tracked calls
- Set **User action naming rules** to map Angular routes to meaningful names
- For lazy-loaded modules, ensure the RUM agent loads before the router initializes

React

React applications typically use React Router or Next.js routing:

- Route changes detected via `history.pushState` (React Router v5+) or `startTransition` (React 18+)
- Component renders tracked through XHR/fetch activity
- No Zone.js — relies on standard browser API monitoring

Configuration tips:

- For Next.js SSR/SSG, use automatic injection on the Node.js server
- For client-only React apps, use manual or agentless injection
- Set **User action naming** to use URL path segments for clearer action names

Vue.js

Vue applications use Vue Router with `history.pushState` or hash mode:

- Route changes detected via `router.afterEach` hook monitoring
- Vuex/Pinia store actions tracked through associated XHR calls

Configuration tips:

- For Nuxt.js, inject the RUM tag in `nuxt.config.js` head configuration
- Enable **Fetch API monitoring** (disabled by default in some configurations)

Note: Regardless of framework, the key setting is enabling **SPA route changes** in your web application configuration. Without it, Dynatrace only captures the initial page load.

```
// Compare action types across applications – identify SPA vs traditional apps
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| summarize action_count = count(), by:{app.name, action.type}
| sort app.name asc, action_count desc
```

If an application shows only `Load` actions and no `RouteChange` or `xhr` actions, SPA instrumentation may not be configured correctly.

5. Custom Action Naming

Default action names like "loading of page /app/dashboard" or "route change to /app/users/12345" can be noisy — especially with dynamic URL segments (IDs, tokens). Custom action naming rules let you normalize names:

Naming Rule Configuration

Configure via **Settings > Web and mobile monitoring > User action naming**:

Rule Type	Example Pattern	Result
URL cleanup	<code>/users/{id}</code> → <code>/users/{*}</code>	Groups all user detail pages
CSS selector	Use <code>data-dtname</code> attribute	<code><button data-dtname="Checkout"></code>
JavaScript variable	Read from SPA router state	Dynamic names from app context
Regex replacement	<code>/api/v[0-9]+/</code> → <code>/api/</code>	Normalize API versions

RUM API for Custom Actions

For fine-grained control, use the Dynatrace JavaScript RUM API:

```
// Start a custom action
const actionId = dtrum.enterAction('Checkout - Payment Step');

// ... perform user interaction ...

// End the action
dtrum.leaveAction(actionId);
```

Let's check for custom actions in our environment:

```
// Find custom user actions – these indicate manual RUM API usage
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| filter action.type == "Custom"
| summarize custom_count = count(), by:{action.name, app.name}
| sort custom_count desc
| limit 15
```

6. XHR and Fetch Monitoring

SPAs rely heavily on asynchronous API calls. Dynatrace monitors both `XMLHttpRequest` and the Fetch API to:

- **Correlate API calls with user actions** — Which button click triggered which API call?
- **Measure API response times** — How long did the backend take?
- **Detect failed requests** — HTTP 4xx/5xx responses and network errors
- **Track third-party calls** — Calls to external APIs, CDNs, analytics services

Enabling Fetch API Monitoring

By default, Dynatrace monitors `XMLHttpRequest`. For modern SPAs using `fetch()`, ensure the setting is enabled:

Settings > Web and mobile monitoring > Async web requests and SPAs > Fetch requests

```
// XHR action performance – identify slow API calls impacting user experience
fetch user.events, from:-1h
| filter action.type == "Xhr"
| summarize xhr_count = count(),
    avg_duration = avg(duration),
    p95_duration = percentile(duration, 95),
    by:{action.name}
| sort p95_duration desc
| limit 15
```

```
// XHR error rate by action – find failing API calls
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| filter action.type == "Xhr"
| summarize total = count(),
    errors = countIf(isNotNull(error.count) and error.count > 0),
    by:{action.name}
| fieldsAdd error_rate_pct = round(toDouble(errors) / toDouble(total) * 100.0,
    decimals: 2)
| filter total > 10
| sort error_rate_pct desc
| limit 10
```

7. Validating SPA Instrumentation

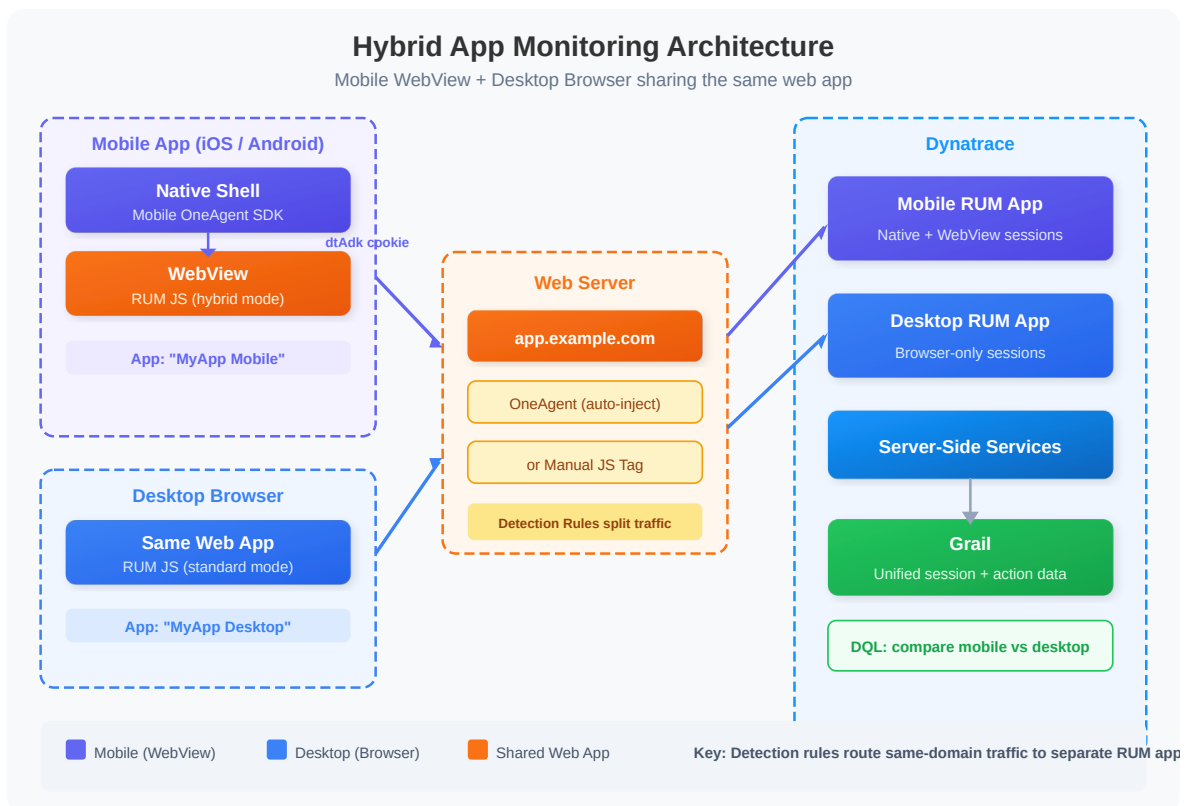
After configuring SPA monitoring, validate that instrumentation is working correctly with this checklist:

Check	DQL Validation	Expected Result
Route changes detected	Query for <code>RouteChange</code> actions	Actions appear for each route
XHR/fetch captured	Query for <code>xhr</code> actions	API calls visible per action
Action names meaningful	Review action name distribution	No generic/unclear names
No duplicate actions	Check for overlapping actions	One action per interaction
Custom actions working	Query for <code>custom</code> type	Developer-defined actions appear


```
// Instrumentation health check – action type distribution per app
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| summarize total_actions = count(), by:{app.name, action.type}
| sort app.name asc, total_actions desc
```

8. Hybrid Apps: Mobile WebView + Desktop

A common pattern is a web application served to both desktop browsers and mobile app WebViews — the same `app.example.com` pages, but consumed in two very different contexts. Dynatrace can monitor both as separate RUM applications with full session correlation.



Architecture Overview

Client	Instrumentation	Dynatrace Application
iOS / Android app	Mobile OneAgent SDK + <code>hybridWebView</code> enabled	Mobile RUM App ("MyApp Mobile")

Client	Instrumentation	Dynatrace Application
Desktop browser	RUM JavaScript (auto-inject or manual tag)	Web RUM App ("MyApp Desktop")

Both clients load the **same web pages** from the same origin, but Dynatrace routes them to **separate applications** using application detection rules.

Step 1: Create Two RUM Applications

In Dynatrace, create two separate applications:

Application	Type	Purpose
MyApp Desktop	Web Application	Desktop/laptop browser traffic
MyApp Mobile	Mobile Application	iOS/Android native + WebView traffic

Step 2: Configure Application Detection Rules

Detection rules route traffic from the same domain to different applications based on request characteristics.

Navigate to **Settings > Web and mobile monitoring > Application detection** and create rules in this order (higher priority first):

Priority	Rule	Condition	Target Application
1	Mobile WebView	User-Agent header contains <code>MyAppName</code> (your app's custom UA string)	MyApp Mobile
2	Desktop fallback	Domain equals <code>app.example.com</code>	MyApp Desktop

Tip: Most mobile apps append a custom identifier to the WebView User-Agent string (e.g., `MyAppName/3.2.1`). Use this as the primary differentiator. If your app doesn't, add one via WebView settings:

```
// Android: Add custom User-Agent suffix
webView.getSettings().setUserAgentString(
    webView.getSettings().getUserAgentString() + " MyAppName/3.2.1"
);
```

```
// iOS: Add custom User-Agent suffix
let config = WKWebViewConfiguration()
config.applicationNameForUserAgent = "MyAppName/3.2.1"
let webView = WKWebView(frame: .zero, configuration: config)
```

Step 3: Enable Hybrid Monitoring in the Mobile SDK

Android (Gradle Plugin)

```
// build.gradle (app module)
dynatrace {
    configurations {
        defaultConfig {
            autoStart {
                applicationId "your-application-id"
                beaconUrl "https://your-env.bf.dynatrace.com/mbeacon"
            }
            hybridWebView {
                enabled true
                domains "app.example.com" // Only instrument your own domain
            }
        }
    }
}
```

Then instrument the WebView instance:

```
// In your Activity or Fragment
import com.dynatrace.android.agent.Dynatrace

val webView = findViewById<WebView>(R.id.webView)
Dynatrace.instrumentWebView(webView)
webView.loadUrl("https://app.example.com")
```

iOS (plist or manual config)

Add to your `Info.plist` :

```
<key>DTXHybridApplication</key>
<true/>
<key>DTXMonitoredDomains</key>
<array>
  <string>app.example.com</string>
</array>
```

Or configure programmatically:

```
import Dynatrace

// In AppDelegate or SceneDelegate
Dynatrace.startupWithInfoPlistSettings()

// When creating a WKWebView
let webView = WKWebView(frame: view.bounds)
// The SDK automatically instruments WKWebView when DTXHybridApplication is
true
```

Step 4: Session Correlation (dtAdk Cookie)

When hybrid monitoring is enabled, the Mobile OneAgent SDK sets a **dtAdk cookie** on the WebView domain. This cookie links the WebView's web session to the native mobile session, creating a **unified session** that includes both native actions (taps, gestures) and web actions (page loads, XHR calls).

Correlation Mechanism	Description
dtAdk cookie	Set by Mobile SDK on the WebView; links web beacon to mobile session
x-dtc header	Propagated on XHR/fetch requests for distributed tracing
applicationId	Routes beacons to the correct Dynatrace application

Important: Only add your own domains to `domains` / `DTXMonitoredDomains`. Never instrument third-party WebViews (e.g., OAuth login pages, payment providers) — this can break functionality and violate privacy policies.

Step 5: Validate the Setup

After deploying both applications, verify that:

1. **Desktop sessions** appear under "MyApp Desktop" with standard browser User-Agents
2. **Mobile WebView sessions** appear under "MyApp Mobile" with your custom UA string
3. **Mobile sessions show both native and web actions** in a single session timeline
4. **Distributed traces** connect WebView XHR calls to server-side services

```
// Compare user action metrics between mobile WebView and desktop browser apps
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| filter application.name == "MyApp Desktop" or application.name == "MyApp
Mobile"
| summarize
    actions = count(),
    avg_duration = avg(duration),
    error_rate = toDouble(countIf(error.count > 0)) / toDouble(count()) *
100,
    by:{application.name, action.type}
| sort application.name asc, actions desc
```

WebView Session Analysis

Identify sessions in the mobile app that include WebView activity — these are your hybrid users.

```
// Identify WebView sessions in the mobile app – these have both native and
web actions
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| filter application.name == "MyApp Mobile"
| summarize
    native_actions = countIf(action.type == "Custom" or action.type ==
"UserAction"),
    web_actions = countIf(in(action.type, {"Load", "RouteChange", "Xhr"})),
    by:{user.session.id}
| filter web_actions > 0
| sort web_actions desc
| limit 20
```

Performance Comparison: Mobile WebView vs Desktop

WebView performance typically differs from desktop browsers due to device constraints, network conditions, and rendering engine differences.

```
// Compare page load performance: mobile WebView vs desktop browser
fetch user.events, from:-24h
| filter action.type == "Load"
| filter application.name == "MyApp Desktop" or application.name == "MyApp Mobile"
| summarize
    p50_duration = percentile(duration, 50),
    p95_duration = percentile(duration, 95),
    avg_dom_interactive = avg(dom.interactive.time),
    actions = count(),
    by:{application.name}
```

9. Summary and Next Steps

In this notebook, we covered:

- **SPA monitoring challenges** — Why traditional page-load tracking fails for SPAs
- **Injection methods** — Automatic, manual, and agentless approaches
- **Route change detection** — How Dynatrace captures SPA navigation
- **Framework-specific tips** — Angular, React, and Vue.js considerations
- **Custom action naming** — Normalizing action names for cleaner analytics
- **XHR/fetch monitoring** — Tracking API call performance and errors
- **Hybrid app setup** — Monitoring mobile WebView and desktop browser as separate RUM applications

Next Steps

- **WEBRUM-03: Core Web Vitals** — Measure LCP, INP, and CLS with DQL
- **WEBRUM-05: Error Analysis** — Deep dive into JavaScript error tracking in SPAs

References

- [User actions in RUM Classic \(DT docs\)](#)

- [Android mobile frontends \(DT docs\)](#)
 - [Web applications in RUM Classic \(DT docs\)](#)
 - [Customize RUM with the JavaScript API \(DT docs\)](#)
 - [Customize RUM with the JavaScript API \(DT docs\)](#)
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